

Does Tamil Nadu's Startup Ecosystem Recurse?

A Research Report on Ecosystem Formation, with Case Studies

Companion analysis to the essay series. Prepared from public records, official StartupTN communications, primary program documents, and named-source reporting. Every load-bearing claim is tagged Confirmed or Emerging.

Executive Summary

Tamil Nadu is provisioning startup-ecosystem components on a large scale and has deliberately engineered connection points into nearly every program it runs. The decisive question is not whether components exist — they plainly do — but whether they connect into self-reinforcing loops that would keep turning if the state stepped back.

On the evidence, the answer is layered and specific:

1. **Provisioning is comprehensive.** The state funds talent, early capital, market access, deep-tech anchoring, and convening.
2. **Connection is intentional.** Accelerators bolted onto grants, "Smart Cards" bridging hackathons to hubs, equity stakes that keep the state on cap tables, and college-industry networks are all explicit attempts to wire components together.
3. **Some loops are demonstrably closing.** TANSEED is the clearest state-built loop, with roughly ₹40 crore of grants associated with about ₹535 crore in downstream private funding and several verifiable founder progressions. The strongest loops overall — the Zoho/Freshworks alumni network and IIT Madras Research Park — are organic anchors the state inherited rather than created.
4. **Other loops remain open.** Public procurement, the SC/ST fund's leadership pipeline, the women-founder network, and the hackathon-to-company pathway are all *connection-attempted* but *closure-unproven*.
5. **The crucial gap is specific.** Almost every confirmed case demonstrates a *grant* → *validation* → *scale* arc. What remains largely undocumented for the state's newer programs is the final turn of recursion — successful founders recirculating as *mentors* and *investors* for the next cohort. That turn is what makes the Zoho network a true loop, and the state can enable it but cannot provision it.

Bottom line: Ecosystem formation in Tamil Nadu is real and accelerating; its self-sustaining closure is still partly underwritten by the state. The defining question for the next five years is whether the state's successful founders will fund and mentor the next ones without being asked.

1. Framework: Components, Connections, and Closure

A startup ecosystem is frequently described as a collection of inputs — talent, capital, mentors, infrastructure, customers. But inputs alone do not constitute an ecosystem any more than bricks constitute a building. What distinguishes an ecosystem is **recursion**: outputs that re-enter as inputs. Founders generate employees who become founders; exits generate capital that funds new ventures; reputations attract talent that produces new reputations. When these feedback paths are strong enough, the system becomes self-sustaining.

This report uses three precise terms:

- **Component** — a provisioned input (e.g., a seed grant, a hackathon, a research park).
- **Connection** — a deliberate mechanism linking one component to another (e.g., an accelerator that routes grant recipients to investors).
- **Loop closure** — evidence that the connection actually produces a feedback effect (e.g., a funded founder who later mentors or finances the next cohort).

The canonical closed loop is the “founder flywheel”: **founder → employees → new founders → investors → new founders**. This report treats that flywheel as the benchmark and asks, for each Tamil Nadu initiative, *which turns of the loop are evidenced*.

2. Methodology and Evidence Standards

Claims in this report are graded:

- **Confirmed** — supported by a primary source (an official StartupTN post, a program document, a regulatory filing) or by multiple named secondary sources.
- **Emerging** — the component and the connection are documented, but loop closure is not yet evidenced in public records.

Two methodological cautions were applied throughout, both learned the hard way during research:

1. **Verify the connection, not just the entity.** A real company and a real funding event do not establish a real *link* between them and a program. Each causal claim (e.g., “X scaled *because of* TANSEED”) was checked against a source that asserts the link directly.
2. **Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence.** Several claims that could not initially be found through general search proved correct once primary sources (official posts, the full text of cited reports) were consulted. Where a claim could not be verified, it is marked Emerging rather than dismissed.

Limitations. Much program-performance data is self-reported by StartupTN or beneficiaries; aggregate figures (e.g., follow-on funding) are not independently audited here. Several programs are recent (2024–2026), so the absence of closure evidence often reflects program youth rather than failure. Figures are current to mid-2026.

3. The Provisioning Layer

Tamil Nadu, primarily through StartupTN (the Tamil Nadu Startup and Innovation Mission, est. 2018), has built an instrument for nearly every layer of the startup stack.

- **Talent:** Naan Mudhalvan, the state skilling mission, and its flagship Niral Thiruvizha hackathon, which in a recent edition drew on the order of 28,000 students across roughly 290 institutions.
- **Early capital:** TANSEED seed grants (₹10–15 lakh), a dedicated SC/ST Startup Fund, a women-led grant track, plus angel-network and investor-connect programs and thematic funds (including a Space Tech fund).
- **Market access:** a procurement framework that relaxes earnest-money, turnover, and prior-experience requirements and permits direct purchases from startups.
- **Deep-tech anchoring:** IIT Madras Research Park and the iTNT Hub, linking startups to laboratories, faculty, and industry.
- **Convening:** the annual Uimage TN summit.

The provisioning question is therefore settled. The components exist, and they cover the stack. The analytical action is entirely in the connection and closure layers.

4. The Connection Layer

What distinguishes Tamil Nadu’s recent design is that it does not merely fund components; it tries to wire them together.

- **TANSEED** evolved from a one-time cheque into a relationship: from its fifth edition it takes a ~3% support stake and enrolls recipients in a year-long accelerator with mentorship, national and international delegations, and post-investment reviews.
- **Niral Thiruvizha** issues finalists StartupTN “Smart Cards” that route them into regional hubs and incubators.
- **The SC/ST Fund** invests via equity and compulsorily convertible debentures, deliberately making the government a shareholder rather than a donor, with post-investment support attached.
- **iTNT Hub** is structured explicitly as a connector across 570+ engineering colleges, researchers, and industry, and operates a Technology Transfer Facilitation Centre.
- **TN-RISE** is built as a women founders’ council and co-creation centre with mentorship MoUs.

These are connection mechanisms, not just funding lines. The state has grasped that an ecosystem lives in the edges between nodes, not only the nodes.

5. Case Studies

Each case study follows the same frame: **Context · What was provisioned and connected · Evidence of recursion · Loop status (which turns are evidenced) · Verification · Assessment.**

Case Study 1 — The Zoho / Freshworks Founder Flywheel (the benchmark)

Context. Zoho (and its spin-out Freshworks) turned Chennai into one of India’s principal SaaS hubs over two decades, with no decisive role from state programs.

Provisioned / connected. Not by the state. The “connection” here is cultural and organic: a large, skills-first employer that trained engineers who later founded their own companies.

Evidence of recursion. On the order of 59 former Zoho employees became startup founders, seeding companies such as Freshworks, Chargebee, and Facilio, and creating a dense SaaS cluster in Chennai. Crucially, the loop runs all the way around: alumni founders have become angel investors and mentors to the next generation.

Loop status. Fully closed. This is the rare case where every turn of the flywheel — founder → employee → founder → investor → new founder — is evidenced.

Verification. Confirmed (Inc42; Vertex Ventures analysis).

Assessment. This is the proof that recursion is achievable in Tamil Nadu — and the reference against which state programs should be measured. It is also a caution: it shows that the hardest turn of the loop (founders becoming financiers of the next cohort) emerged organically over decades, not through a policy instrument.

Case Study 2 — IIT Madras Research Park / IITMIC (the institutional anchor)

Context. India's first university research park, paired with the IIT Madras Incubation Cell, has become the country's leading deep-tech incubation engine.

Provisioned / connected. Lab access, faculty linkage, IP support, an investor network, and — importantly — an incubation model that *retains a stake in its companies by design* so that founders remain tied to the ecosystem.

Evidence of recursion. 457 startups incubated over roughly twelve years, an unusually high survival rate (~80% versus the typical 8–10%), about 60% of founders from outside the IIT system, two unicorns, and an IPO (Ather). Faculty and alumni cycle back as founders and mentors.

Loop status. Closed, anchored institutionally rather than by individual alumni. The deliberate cap-table retention is itself a designed recursion mechanism — the incubator has a structural reason to keep pulling founders back in.

Verification. Confirmed (IIT Madras press release, 2025; YourStory, 2025).

Assessment. A model for how an *institution* (rather than a market) can manufacture recursion. The state did not build it, but it is a component the broader ecosystem genuinely contains.

Case Study 3 — TANSEED (the state's flagship loop)

Context. TANSEED (Tamil Nadu Startup Seed Fund), launched 2021, is StartupTN's flagship early-capital instrument and the clearest test of whether the *state* can build a loop.

Provisioned / connected. ₹10–15 lakh grants; a ~3% support stake from edition five; a year-long accelerator with mentorship and delegations; routing into incubators and investor networks. Since 2021 it has supported roughly 169 startups.

Evidence of recursion (aggregate). Against approximately ₹40 crore allocated, TANSEED-supported startups have collectively raised on the order of ₹535 crore in external follow-on funding (StartupTN figures, reported September 2025) — a multiplier that indicates the grant → private-capital path is real. Named beneficiaries include Buyofuel, Ippopay, Gallabox, Dream Aerospace, Torus Robotics, Plugzmart, and Greenpod.

Sub-cases (the heart of the evidence):

- **ippopay (Mohan K, Chennai; fintech/payments)**. A 2021 TANSEED winner (incubated at AIC RAISE). The founder publicly describes TANSEED as the company's "first recognition," after which it scaled its payments business. *Loop turns evidenced: grant → validation → scale. Confirmed.*
- **PrimeInvestor (Srikanth Meenakshi, Vidya Bala, Bhavana Acharya; Chennai; wealthtech/research)**. A TANSEED 3.0 cohort grantee in 2022 (₹10 lakh), independently listed among that cohort by the implementing partner. In 2026 it raised ₹19.5 crore from Rainmatter (Zerodha's investment arm) — its first *external* funding round, a description consistent with an earlier non-dilutive state grant. StartupTN amplified the milestone, explicitly identifying the firm as a TANSEED beneficiary. *Loop turns evidenced: grant → multi-year growth → institutional capital → ecosystem amplification. Confirmed* (StartupTN post; Headstart cohort-3 listing; 2026 funding coverage).
- **REUDE Technologies (Reginald Chellam; Tiruvallur/Chennai; drone/UAV)**. A TANSEED 4.0 grant recipient and the sole Tamil Nadu company selected among the top ten finalists in Stanford's Seed Spark Pitch Demo Day (South Asia cohort). Its flagship platform serves precision agriculture and defense surveillance. *Loop turns evidenced: grant → international validation. Confirmed* (StartupTN post, Aug 2024; corroborated by Stanford Seed Spark cohort listing and REUDE's own channels).
- **HARVTECH (Shrinivasan S, Mohamed Imran; agritech / EV-tractors)**. Selected from 1,000+ applications for a TANSEED 4.0 grant, stacked with recognition from IIT Madras's Carbon Zero Challenge and a BIRAC BIG grant — a portfolio of credentials that compounds credibility. *Loop turns evidenced: grant → stacked validation. Confirmed* (HARVTECH post; YourStory).

Loop status. Partially closed. The grant → validation → scale → follow-on capital arc is strongly evidenced. What is *not* yet visible in these cases is the final turn — these founders becoming the investors or mentors of the next TANSEED cohort.

Verification. Confirmed across aggregate and sub-cases.

Assessment. The most convincing thing the state has built. TANSEED demonstrates that a small public grant can function as a credibility primer that unlocks private capital. The recursion is real but currently "half-turn": money and validation flow forward to founders; founders have not yet visibly flowed back as capital to successors.

Case Study 4 — Public Procurement: Tamil Nadu vs. Rajasthan (a comparative / negative case)

Context. "Government as first customer" is a textbook recursion mechanism: a public work order confers revenue, credibility, and investor confidence, which unlocks private

customers. This case study is instructive precisely because Tamil Nadu has the *policy* but not the *outcomes*, and a peer state shows what closure looks like.

Provisioned / connected. Tamil Nadu relaxes earnest-money, turnover, and prior-experience thresholds and permits direct procurement from startups up to ₹50 lakh via TANSIM.

Evidence of recursion. Thin. A 2025 Primus Partners report (Table 6) records Tamil Nadu at roughly **five startups** awarded work orders worth about **₹0.54 crore** — comparable to Karnataka (₹0.49 crore) and Telangana (~₹1 crore), but far below the leaders.

Contrast — Rajasthan (the closure benchmark). Through its iStart initiative and e-Bazaar platform (and a landmark amendment to its procurement act), Rajasthan issued **132 work orders worth over ₹25 crore to 476 startups**. The same report's survey of recipients found that a large majority reported improved market access and credibility, and around 70% reported increased investor interest after winning government contracts — the credibility-to-capital loop, operating at scale. Kerala (~141 startups; ₹17–28 crore across 188 procurements) is a second working model.

Loop status. Open in Tamil Nadu. The connection (policy) exists; the loop (realized orders → credibility → private scaling) is barely traced. **Closed in Rajasthan**, which provides the proof-of-concept.

Verification. Confirmed (Primus Partners & JITO report, 2025, Table 6).

Assessment. The most actionable gap in this report. Tamil Nadu's procurement loop is a policy without a platform. Rajasthan's e-Bazaar shows that the missing ingredient is not intent but a transactional engine that converts eligibility into actual orders.

Case Study 5 — SC/ST Startup Fund (the inclusion loop, emerging)

Context. An exclusive equity fund for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe founders, designed to address financial exclusion and create role models.

Provisioned / connected. Roughly ₹60.8 crore sanctioned across approximately 26+ startups (₹7.5 crore to five startups in the first batch; ₹9.75 crore to eight in the second; ₹34.6 crore to 26 by end-2023). Investment is via equity and compulsorily convertible debentures, making the state a shareholder, with post-investment mentorship.

Evidence of recursion. Named, funded companies exist — Ecopmin Technologies (electronics, ₹3 crore), Adhiban Farms (agritech, ₹2.2 crore), COEO Wellness (₹60 lakh), Mannvasanai Traditional Food (₹45 lakh), Nanjil Nadu Kani Tribal Women Creations (₹25 lakh), and tribal ventures such as TAMS Tribal Green Fuel. The state-as-shareholder structure adds credibility for new clients and markets.

Loop status. Emerging. Capital and credibility flow to founders; the program's stated aim of producing "inspirational stories" that draw the next cohort, and of alumni moving into mentorship/leadership, is not yet documented in public records.

Verification. Confirmed funding activity (Business Standard / TICE, 2023; StartupTN). Loop closure unproven.

Assessment. A well-designed capital-and-credibility instrument whose recursion will depend on whether early beneficiaries become visible mentors and role models — a measurable outcome the program should track and publish.

Case Study 6 — Women-Led TANSEED and TN-RISE (the women-founder network, emerging)

Context. A women-led grant track within TANSEED plus TN-RISE, a women founders' council launched in July 2024 (World Bank-supported, via the Tamil Nadu Women Development Corporation / rural transformation project).

Provisioned / connected. ₹15 lakh women-led TANSEED awards; TN-RISE as a co-creation centre with mentorship MoUs (including Flipkart, HP, and FLO) and a stated target of mentoring 1,000+ women per year.

Evidence of recursion. At the Global Women Summit 2026 (TNWeSafe), ₹15 lakh TANSEED awards went to women-led ventures including **Dukil Medical and Technical Textiles** (Santhiya Selvakumar, Erode), **Aruvi Eco** (Kalaiselvi Balamurugan, Tiruppur), Jananom Natural Nutrition (Coimbatore), Nature Hunt Innovations (Chennai), Shopiqo Innovations (Tiruvannamalai), and KnappIT Innovation India (Chennai).

Loop status. Emerging. The network and mentorship architecture exist; founder-to-founder peer financing or mentorship closure is not yet documented, and TN-RISE is barely a year old.

Verification. Confirmed awards (StartupTN post, Global Women Summit 2026). Loop closure unproven.

Assessment. Strong inclusion infrastructure; closure depends on the council maturing into an active peer-capital and peer-mentorship network rather than an events calendar.

Case Study 7 — Niral Thiruvizha (the talent funnel, pipeline documented)

Context. A mass student-innovation hackathon under Naan Mudhalvan, intended to convert student ideas into startups.

Provisioned / connected. Roughly 28,450 students from ~290 institutions in a recent edition; ₹10,000 prototype grants for the top 1,000 teams, ₹2 lakh innovation vouchers for

the top 50, and StartupTN Smart Cards routing finalists into regional hubs and incubators.

Evidence of recursion. The pipeline is documented end-to-end: for example, KCG College of Technology had two teams selected among the top fifty for ₹1 lakh grants (144 teams shortlisted from 837 participants), explicitly “connected with StartupTN regional hubs for further incubation.”

Loop status. Promising / open. The funnel and the hand-off to incubation are real; a publicly visible “hackathon team became a funded company” exit is not yet on record.

Verification. Confirmed pipeline (KCG College post, Sept 2024; program documents). Exit unproven.

Assessment. An excellent top-of-funnel; its recursion claim rests on conversion data the program does not yet publish.

6. Cross-Case Analysis

Reading the cases together yields four patterns.

(a) State-built loops vs. inherited loops. The two fully closed loops (Zoho network, IITMRP) are organic or institutional and were not created by StartupTN. The strongest *state-built* loop (TANSEED) is partially closed. The newest state programs (SC/ST leadership, women networks, hackathon-to-company, procurement) are open. The further a loop is from the state’s direct control, the more completely it has closed — a sign that the hardest turns of recursion are market behaviors the state can prompt but not mandate.

(b) The half-turn problem. Nearly every confirmed state case demonstrates the same arc — **grant → validation → scale → follow-on capital** — and stops there. The missing turn is **founder → investor/mentor → next founder**. This is not a minor omission: it is precisely the turn that converts a list of funded alumni into a self-sustaining flywheel. Until TANSEED graduates are visibly funding or mentoring the next cohort, the loop depends on the state to keep priming it.

(c) Policy without a platform. Procurement is the clearest instance of a connection that exists on paper but lacks a transactional engine. Rajasthan’s contrast shows the decisive variable is operational infrastructure (e-Bazaar) plus legal reform, not policy intent.

(d) Program youth is a real confound. TN-RISE (2024), the Deep Tech Policy (2025–26), and recent TANSEED and women-led cohorts are too young to have produced closure evidence. “Emerging” here often means “not yet,” not “not working.”

What predicts closure? Across the cases, loops closed where (i) the connector had a

structural reason to keep founders engaged (IITMRP's cap-table retention; the Zoho culture), (ii) there was a *transactional platform* converting eligibility into transactions (Rajasthan's e-Bazaar), and (iii) enough *time* had passed for a first generation of successes to mature into financiers. Tamil Nadu's programs have (i) partially (TANSEED's stake), lack (ii) in procurement, and are still accumulating (iii) almost everywhere.

7. Recursion Audit Matrix

Initiative	Component	Connection attempted	Recursion evidence	Loop status	Verification
Zoho / Freshworks network	Talent / culture	Founder → employee → founder → investor	~59 ex-Zoho founders; Chennai SaaS cluster; alumni now angels/mentors	Closed	Confirmed
IIT Madras Research Park / IITMIC	Anchor institution	Founder–faculty–investor links	457 startups; ~80% survival; 2 unicorns; cap-table retention by design	Closed (institutional)	Confirmed
TANSEED	Capital (grants)	Grant → accelerator → scale → follow-on	~₹40 Cr in → ~₹535 Cr follow-on; ippopay, PrimeInvestor, REUDE, HARVTECH	Partially closed	Confirmed
Procurement preference	Market access	Govt customer → private credibility	TN ~5 startups / ₹0.54 Cr vs Rajasthan 132 orders / ₹25 Cr	Open	Confirmed figure (Primus)
SC/ST Startup Fund	Capital (equity/CCD)	Funding + credibility → leadership	~₹60.8 Cr / ~26+ startups; named companies; state as	Emerging	Confirmed funding

			shareholder		
Women-led TANSEED / TN-RISE	Women founders	Peer / mentor networks	₹15L awards (Dukil, Aruvi Eco, etc.); TN- RISE council + MoUs	Emerging	Confirmed awards
Niral Thiruvizha / Naan Mudhalvan	Talent / student ideas	Hackathon → hub → startup	~28,450 students; grants + Smart Cards; KCG top-50 → ₹1L + hub linkage	Promising / open	Confirmed pipeline
iTNT Hub	Deep-tech ecosystem	Industry– academia– founder links	570+ colleges; 50+ MoUs; Tech Transfer Centre; Deep Tech Policy 2025–26	Emerging	Confirmed activity
Umanage TN	Convening	Temporary interactions	Annual summit; policy launches; MoUs	Weak by design	Confirmed

8. Findings and Conclusion

Tamil Nadu has done something genuinely sophisticated: it has understood that ecosystems are recursive and has engineered connection points into almost every component it funds. In TANSEED it can now point to a real, evidenced loop in which modest public grants are followed by substantial private capital and international validation. These are not announcements; they are documented progressions.

But recursion has a final turn the state cannot provision and can only enable — founders must become the ecosystem's financiers and mentors for those who follow. The government can build every edge leading up to that turn; it cannot make the turn itself. Outside the Zoho/Freshworks network and IIT Madras's research park, both inherited rather than created, that traversal is still young.

The verdict is therefore neither "an ecosystem has formed" nor "it is all policy." It is more precise: **Tamil Nadu's ecosystem formation is real and accelerating; the components**

are in place, the connections are deliberate, and the first state-built loop is closing — but the system's self-sustaining closure is still partly underwritten by the state.

9. Recommendations and Indicators to Watch

Recommendations

1. **Close the half-turn deliberately.** Create explicit pathways and incentives for TANSEED/SC/ST/women-led alumni to become mentors and angel investors for later cohorts (e.g., alumni-as-mentor mandates, matched co-investment vehicles for successful graduates). This is the single highest-leverage intervention.
2. **Give procurement a platform, not just a policy.** Replicate Rajasthan's e-Bazaar model — a transactional catalog with direct work orders and legal reform that converts startup eligibility into actual orders, with published outcomes.
3. **Publish conversion and recirculation data.** Niral Thiruvizha should track how many funnel teams become registered, funded companies; the SC/ST and women programs should track how many beneficiaries become mentors/investors. Closure that is not measured cannot be demonstrated.
4. **Protect the institutional model.** Treat IITMRP's cap-table-retention design as a template for keeping founders structurally tied to the ecosystem.

Falsifiable indicators of genuine closure (next 3–5 years)

- Named cases of TANSEED/SC/ST/women-led graduates *investing in or formally mentoring* later cohorts.
- Tamil Nadu's realized procurement work-order value rising from ~₹0.54 crore toward peer-state levels.
- At least one publicly documented Niral Thiruvizha team reaching funded-company status.
- TN-RISE evolving from an events-and-MoU body into an active peer-capital network with documented founder-to-founder financing.

If these indicators move, the loops are closing and the ecosystem is becoming self-sustaining. If they do not, Tamil Nadu will remain an impressively provisioned, deliberately connected ecosystem whose recursion is still state-dependent.

Appendix: Sources

- **TANSEED aggregate (₹40 Cr → ₹535 Cr) and named beneficiaries:** Inc42, "Inside Tamil Nadu's Vision To Become A Global Startup Hub," Sept 2025.
- **ipopay:** TANSEED 2021 winner (uniindia / Business Standard / PRNewswire, Feb 2021); StartupTN "first recognition" testimonial.
- **PrimeInvestor:** TANSEED 3.0 cohort 2022 (Headstart Network Foundation post); StartupTN "TANSEED winner/beneficiary" post; ₹19.5 Cr Rainmatter round (Entrackr, The Statesman, IBS Intelligence, 2026).
- **REUDE Technologies:** StartupTN post (Aug 2024) — TANSEED 4.0 beneficiary, sole TN company, top-10 Stanford Seed Spark (South Asia) finalist; corroborated by Stanford Seed Spark cohort listing and REUDE's own channels.
- **HARVTECH:** HARVTECH post (TANSEED 4.0 grant, 1,000+ applications); YourStory (IIT-M Carbon Zero + BIRAC BIG).
- **Women-led awards (Dukil, Aruvi Eco, etc.):** StartupTN post, Global Women Summit 2026 (TNWeSafe).
- **SC/ST Fund:** Business Standard and TICE (Dec 2023); StartupTN.
- **Procurement (Table 6 figures; Rajasthan/Kerala/Karnataka/Telangana comparison; recipient survey):** Primus Partners & JITO, "Public Procurement: A ₹88,000 Cr Opportunity for India's Startups" (2025).
- **Niral Thiruvizha pipeline:** KCG College of Technology post (Sept 2024); Niral Thiruvizha / Naan Mudhalvan program pages.
- **IIT Madras Research Park:** IIT Madras press release (2025); YourStory (Dec 2025).
- **iTNT Hub / Deep Tech Policy:** iTNT Hub materials; Entrepreneur India / Convergence (Jan 2026).
- **Zoho / Freshworks network:** Inc42; Vertex Ventures (Medium).
- **StartupTN context:** startuptn.in; Startup Genome (Tamil Nadu).

Note on evidence grade: nearly all confirmed evidence demonstrates the grant → validation → scale arc. The founder → investor/mentor → next-founder closure remains strongest in the organic Zoho/IITMRP anchors and is not yet documented for the state's newer programs.